Women's Specialists of Clear Lake
Geffrey H. Klein, MD · FACOG · DABOM

400 W Medical Center Blvd, Suite 300
Webster, Texas 77598 · (281) 557-0300

Pregnancy & Healthy Weight Gain

How much weight should I gain? What should I eat? Answers to your most common questions.

RECOMMENDED WEIGHT GAIN

Your recommended pregnancy weight gain depends on your **pre-pregnancy BMI**:

Pre-Pregnancy BMI	Category	Total Gain
<18.5	Underweight	28–40 lbs
18.5–24.9	Normal weight	25–35 lbs
25–29.9	Overweight	15–25 lbs
≥30	Obese	11–20 lbs
Twins	Normal BMI	37–54 lbs

Source: Institute of Medicine / ACOG 2024 Guidelines

EXTRA CALORIE NEEDS

1st Trimester	**+0 calories**	No extra calories needed; focus on folate & iron
2nd Trimester	**+340 cal/day**	Baby is growing rapidly; protein important
3rd Trimester	**+450 cal/day**	Brain development; omega-3s & calcium key

Best Foods to Emphasize:

- Lean proteins (chicken, fish, legumes, eggs)
- Dairy or fortified alternatives (calcium)
- Dark leafy greens (iron, folate)
- Whole grains (fiber, B vitamins)
- Fruits and colorful vegetables
- Low-mercury fish (salmon, tilapia, cod) 2–3×/week

AVOID DURING PREGNANCY

Always Avoid:

- **Alcohol** — no safe amount
- High-mercury fish (shark, swordfish, king mackerel, bigeye tuna)
- Raw or undercooked meat, eggs, seafood
- Unpasteurized cheeses and deli meats (Listeria risk)
- Raw sprouts
- Excessive caffeine (>200mg/day; ≈1 cup coffee)

Limit or Use Caution:

- Artificial sweeteners — limit use
- Processed foods high in sodium
- Herbal teas and supplements (check with Dr. Klein)

ESSENTIAL NUTRIENTS & SUPPLEMENTS

Folate/Folic Acid — 600–800 mcg/day

Prevents neural tube defects. Start before conception. Found in leafy greens, beans, fortified foods.

Iron — 27 mg/day

Prevents anemia; supports fetal oxygen supply. Red meat, spinach, fortified cereals. Take with vitamin C for absorption.

Calcium — 1,000 mg/day

Fetal bone and tooth development. Dairy, fortified foods, leafy greens.

Vitamin D — 600 IU/day

Works with calcium; immune support. Most prenatal vitamins contain adequate amounts.

DHA (Omega-3) — 200–300 mg/day

Fetal brain and eye development. Found in fatty fish; many prenatal vitamins include DHA.

EXERCISE IN PREGNANCY

Safe & Recommended Activities:

- Walking (30 min most days)
- Swimming and water aerobics
- Prenatal yoga and stretching
- Stationary cycling
- Low-impact aerobics
- Modified strength training

Avoid These Activities:

- Contact sports or collision risk
- Hot yoga or exercising in extreme heat
- Lying flat on back after 20 weeks
- High-altitude activities if not acclimatized
- Scuba diving

Stop exercising and call if you have:

Vaginal bleeding, contractions, difficulty breathing, chest pain, or significant decrease in fetal movement

OBESITY IN PREGNANCY FAQS

Q: Do I need to gain less weight if I'm obese?

Yes — ACOG recommends only **11–20 lbs total** for women with BMI ≥30. Some women with severe obesity may safely gain less or none with physician supervision.

Q: Are weight loss medications safe in pregnancy?

No. All anti-obesity medications (GLP-1 agonists, phentermine, etc.) should be stopped before conception or immediately upon discovering pregnancy.

Q: What are my increased risks with obesity in pregnancy?

Gestational diabetes, preeclampsia, C-section, preterm birth, and macrosomia (large baby). These are monitored closely throughout your care.

Q: When can I restart weight management after delivery?

Usually 6 weeks postpartum for diet/exercise. If breastfeeding, medication decisions are made individually. Dr. Klein will create a postpartum plan.

Healthy Weight Gain = Healthier Pregnancy for Mom and Baby

Following your personalized weight gain guidelines reduces risks for both you and your baby. Dr. Klein provides expert OB care with specialized expertise in obesity medicine — we'll monitor your weight and nutrition throughout your pregnancy. Call us at **(281) 557-0300**

.